The Care Requirements Checklist

What to confirm, write down and ask before you compare care arrangements for your wife.

The social worker has started saying “assisted living” and “memory care.” Before anyone compares one arrangement with another, make sure you have these in hand. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is a job for the coming days, not a verdict about your wife or about you.

Write down

- [ ] Your earlier list of her needs and gaps, read through once more. If you never made one, your own account of a day with her is the place to start.
- [ ] The tasks she gets help with, one per line, in plain words: who steadies her when she stands, who reminds her to eat lunch, who sets out her clothes. [1]
- [ ] When each kind of help happens, only where you've seen it yourself or someone on her care team has documented it. Everywhere else, write “not confirmed.”
- [ ] How she gets around and how she makes herself understood: what she holds or uses to move, and what helps a conversation go well.
- [ ] Which items on your list are essential and which are preferences, in two columns, with what matters to her kept in her own words. [2]

Confirm

- [ ] Which of the help on your list her care team agrees she requires now. Show the list to her doctor, her nurse or her therapist and mark what they confirm.
- [ ] The clinical capabilities her care team says are required, copied in their words, with who said it and the date.
- [ ] What each person in the family can realistically keep doing, including you, by day and by hour. [1]

Ask

- [ ] Your questions about supervision, written as questions for the people who assess her. Leave the answers to them.
- [ ] The questions that have to be settled before a setting is chosen, each with the name of the person who can answer it.
- [ ] For each essential, the question you'd put to any arrangement: can you do this, who does it, and at what hours?
- [ ] Who will look over the questions about her level of care that are still open: her doctor, the social worker or your care consultant.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you confirm, write down and ask. It doesn't say what a checked or an unchecked box means, what kind of care your wife needs, or which setting would suit her. Those belong to the people who assess her, and to the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You know what to confirm, write down and ask. The care interview goes through your wife's daily life area by area, including the parts that don't show up at home, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 follow the questions the Family Caregiver Alliance suggests families write answers to; the item marked 2 follows the National Institute on Aging's advice to consider the person's needs and wants. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources
2. National Institute on Aging, How To Choose a Nursing Home or Other Long-Term Care Facility